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Conceptual Referent for Happiness: Cross-Country Comparisons

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Abstract:

This paper is based on the Conceptual Referent Theory of Happiness, which states that people must have a conceptual referent for what a happy life means in order to assess their life as a happy one. The paper studies the existence of heterogeneity across countries in the inclination towards different conceptual referents for happiness. Empirical information comes from surveys applied to students in Cuba, Norway, and South Africa. It is found that there is statistically significant heterogeneity across countries regarding the conceptions of happiness and the way different inclinations towards these conceptions relate to happiness. This heterogeneity is relevant because it implies that the relevant resources for happiness may differ across countries and, moreover, across cultures.

Keywords: Happiness, Conceptual Referent, Cross-Country Comparisons, Social Construction

Introduction

The Conceptual Referent Theory of Happiness (CRT) states that people hold different conceptions for what a happy life is, and that these conceptions play a role in the resources that are relevant for having a happy life. The theory is also important to understand the manner in which people behave in their pursuit of happiness.

The theory states that conceptions of happiness differ not only across people, but also across cultures, since the conception one holds is not independent of the specific personal and social context one lives in and grew up. Hence, the conception of what a happy life means – but not necessarily the notion of happiness being the ultimate goal – may vary across cultures.³

In addition, the theory states that differences in the conception of happiness do extend to the relevant resources for a happy life; thus, resources that may be crucial for some people and in some cultures could be irrelevant for other people and in different cultures. The theory has been tested in Mexico, where it was found that people hold different conceptions for happiness (Rojas, 2005) and that the conception a person holds is relevant for the role of income as an

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3 This argument has been advanced by Rojas (2005, 2007), as well as by Camfield *et al.* (2006). For a group of studies on the relationship between culture and subjective well-being see Diener and Suh (2000)

explanatory variable of happiness (Rojas, 2007). However, a cross-culture research is needed to test the theory's postulate about differences across cultures.

This paper is based on a survey applied in 2005 to 476 university students in three countries: Norway, South Africa and Cuba, to test the theory's postulate for differences across cultures. Even though the process of globalization could imply that students be relatively culturally homogeneous across countries, it is possible to state that there are big cultural differences among these countries based on their language, world location, history, political and economic regimes, and dominant religion and values, among other criteria.

The investigation finds that people are equally happy in the three countries, even under different social conditions, and that people significantly differ across countries in their view of what happiness means.

Section 2 deals with *CRT*'s justification and relevance, as well as with the construction and operation of a typology of conceptual referents for happiness. Section 3 explains the cross-country surveys, and the construction of happiness and conceptual-referent variables. It shows that there are no significant differences in happiness across countries. Section 4 studies differences in the conceptions of happiness across countries, and the way in which these conceptions relate to happiness. Section 5 deals with the socio-demographics of conceptual referents for happiness and its differences across countries. Section 6 formulates some final considerations.

On the Conceptual-Referent for Happiness Theory

On the Theory

The Conceptual Referent theory (*CRT*) focuses on a person's notion of what a happy life is (Rojas, 2005)⁴ The theory states that one must have a conceptual referent for what a happy life is in order to appraise life and respond to subjective well-being question.⁵ Hence, *CRT* states that "a person has a conceptual referent for a happy life and that this referent plays a role in the judgement of her life and in the appraisal of her happiness. In consequence, *CRT* claims that a person's judgement about her happiness is contingent on her conceptual referent for a happy life." (Rojas, 2005, p. 262)

Without neglecting the role played by transient emotions,⁶ the *CRT* emphasizes that a happiness assessment involves a judgemental process, in which a person must select the information and issues that are relevant for assessing life as a happy one.⁷ As Lyubomirsky (2001) states "As many psychologists and philosophers have noted, people do not only experience events or situations passively. Rather, all life events are 'cognitively processed'... – that is, construed and framed, evaluated and interpreted, contemplated and remembered... – so that each individual may live in a separate subjective social world" (p. 240).

CRT differs from philosophical and top-down approaches to happiness (Tatarkiewicz, 1976; McFall, 1989; Chekola, 1974; and mostly all philosophers), which are basically deductive and

4 In a broad sense, the conceptual referent a person holds is part of what a person is; therefore, it could be considered as part of her personality, if personality is understood in a broad sense, comprising "not simple traits but also the goals for which individuals typically strive." (Diener, 1999, p. 224) See also Emmons (1986) and Little (1989)

5 Thus, *CRT* is directly concerned with the process through which a person makes a judgment of her well-being, rather than with the surrounding survey conditions. A conceptual referent for a happy life is needed to make a judgment and to express a reported happiness, even in the case of a quick judgment.

6 Schwarz & Strack (1991, 1999)

7 Diener & Lucas (2000, p. 41) have proposed an Evaluation-Theory model "in which SWB (subjective well-being) depends on people's evaluations of self-relevant information. Attention is selective and therefore the factors that determine its focus are likely to influence evaluations of events."

normative in their consideration of what a happy life is. *CRT* borrows from philosophical discourse, but it focuses on people's own understanding of the concept of happiness; which is the concept at work when they are assessing their life as a happy one. As stated by Haybron (2003, p. 210) "The concept of happiness is, as I noted earlier, a folk notion; 'happiness' is not a technical term for theorists to use as they please. Happiness is primarily a matter of *practical* concern for ordinary people trying to lead good lives. Empirical researchers are no more entitled to co-opt it for their parochial purposes than moral theorists are. And it is quite possible that, left to their own devices, empirical researchers would arrive at a conception of happiness that is not especially well-suited for dealing with the practical concerns of laypersons."⁸

CRT also stresses the importance of heterogeneity; this is: the conceptual referent is not the same for every person. Thus, the relevance of the conceptual referent for happiness a person holds is that it provides an explanation for people behaving differently in their pursuit of happiness. A related argument has also been made by Diener & Fujita (1995), Diener & Lucas (2000) and Eid & Diener (2004)

Rojas (2007) shows that heterogeneity in the conceptual referent extends also to the explanatory structure of happiness. This means that the set of variables and the nature of their relationship that explains a person's happiness are contingent on her conceptual referent. Some explanatory factors are relevant for some people but not for others, and this depends on their conceptual referent. This fact contributes to explain why people may follow different paths in their pursuit of a happy life; as well as why people may be happy even under different social conditions. Thus, *CRT* is important for understanding what resources are relevant for having a happy life and why these resources may differ across persons and across nations. It breaks with the assumption of universality in the explanatory structure of happiness across people and cultures.

On building a typology of conceptual referents

What do people mean when they state they are happy or unhappy? What do they have in mind when they appraise their life as a whole in order to answer a subjective well-being question? Does everybody have the same conceptual referent for happiness? To study the conception of happiness that people hold when assessing their life as a happy one it is useful to build a typology of happiness conceptions. Then, people can be asked about their inclination towards different conceptions of happiness. Rojas (2005) presents a typology of happiness concepts constructed on the basis of an extensive review of philosophical essays about what happiness is.⁹ Philosophers hold complex and opposite views on many issues, and this is especially true when dealing with happiness.¹⁰ The investigation simplified and classified philosophical views into eight conceptual referents for happiness: *Stoicism*, *Virtue*, *Enjoyment*, *Carpe Diem*, *Satisfaction*, *Utopian*, *Tranquillity*, and *Fulfilment*.¹¹

The words of philosophers, bearing a high degree of sophistication, are not easily understood

8 There is a related literature on lay theories of happiness (Furnham, 1988; Furnham & Cheng, 2000). However, lay theories have focused more on attributed causes of happiness rather than on the understanding of happiness itself.

9 The author is grateful to Lourdes Rodríguez for her work in the construction of the philosophical survey (Rodríguez, 2001). Being the topic so widely discussed, this survey can not claim to be exhaustive.

10 The philosophers' work on what happiness is both reflects -in a very refined way- and inspires the common wisdom that resonates in the minds of ordinary people and which influences their pursuit of happiness.

11 The main objective for creating a typology is to reduce and condense a large set of issues into a simple classification, which can be used for research purposes. It is obvious that some of the richness of the philosophical debate is lost in the process of simplification. In addition, a philosopher's thought is very complex, and Table 2 can not capture such a complexity; therefore, the placement of a philosopher's thought in the typology must be considered as a source of inspiration rather than a categorical statement about his position; the investigation's objectives require it to be so.

by common people. Thus, the conceptual referents for happiness must be presented in simple and recognizable phrases common people can relate to. A focus-group exercise in Mexico lead to a set of phrases people can easily understand and which maintain the conceptions' essence as much as possible. The eight conceptual referents, a brief description, and the set of simple phrases are presented in Table 1.

Table 1: *Typology: The Conceptual Referent for Happiness*

Conceptual Referent	Some References	Brief Description	Simple Phrase
Stoicism	Marco Aurelio, Epictetus.	Happiness is a permanent state of contentment with life and with what happens in life. This state implies renunciation, austerity, acceptance, and resignation; taking things as they are and as they come out.	„Happiness is accepting things as they are”
Virtue	Socrates, Descartes, Saint Thomas of Aquino.	Happiness is a spiritual state produced by the feeling of acting properly, according to one's consciousness.	„Happiness is a sense of acting properly in our relations with others and with ourselves”
Enjoyment	Hedonism and Utilitarianism of Bentham, Mill, La Mettrie. Positivism of Comte.	Happiness is joyfulness and absence of pain, it is the enjoyment of those goods that provide comfort. It is the satisfaction of all human needs and wants.	„Happiness is to enjoy what one has attain in life”
Carpe diem	Erasmus	Happiness is the present pleasure and gratification, it is about enjoying now as much as possible.	„Happiness is to seize every moment in life”
Satisfaction	Psychological approaches, Argyle, Sumner	Happiness is a feeling of life's elation that comes with an intuitive judgement about oneself and about one's surrounding world.	„Happiness is being satisfied with what I have and what I am”
Utopian	Plato, Thomas Moro, Kant, Kierkegaard, Bloch.	Happiness is an ideal that guides human action. It is perfection itself conceptualised as the synthesis of virtue and pleasure. It is a desired, yet unreachable good, at least in this life.	„Happiness is an unreachable ideal we can only try to approach”
Tranquillity	Epicurus, Diogenes, Adam Smith.	Happiness is a state of tranquillity, the absence of worries that takes place with prudence, moderation, measurement, and judicious wants.	„Happiness is in living a tranquil life, not looking beyond what is attainable”
Fulfilment	Aristotle, Chuang Tzu	Happiness is the realization of our nature and the fulfilment of our essence as human beings. Happiness is in that activity that constitutes the ultimate goal of each human being.	„Happiness is in fully exercising our capabilities”

Source: In Rojas (2005)

Cross-Country Surveys

Sampling

Data were collected in 2005 among students from the University of Tromsø, Norway (N= 144), students from the University of Western Cape, South Africa (N = 182) and students from the University of Havana, Cuba (N = 150). All three are convenience samples, as participants were recruited from lectures or at the campus. There were 111 (77%) females in the Norwegian sample, 139 (77%) females in the South African sample, and 69 (46%) females in the Cuban sample. Mean ages (with Range and Standard deviations) were 24,4 (R = 19-48, SD = 6.0); 24.0 (R=18-44, SD = 5.3) and 22.1 (R = 14 - 48, SD = 4.8) respectively for the three samples.

Construction of a happiness variable

Happiness was measured by means of the Subjective Happiness Scale (SHS; Lyubomirsky & Lepper, 1999). The SHS is a 4-item inventory, asking participants to indicate the extent to which they identify themselves as a happy person on a 1 to 7 scale with varying end point labels. The Cronbach alpha's for the scale were $\alpha = .82$; $\alpha = .74$; and $\alpha = .64$ for the Norwegian, South African, and Cuban samples respectively. The English and Spanish versions of the SHS were provided by Sonia Lyubomirsky, and the Norwegian version was translated and back-translated from the English version by three bilingual persons.

Tables 2 and 3 present basic statistics for the happiness variable and for their statistical comparison across countries.

Table 2: *Mean and Standard Deviation Values for Happiness*

By country			
	Norway	South Africa	Cuba
Mean	4.61	4.71	4.60
Standard Deviation	1.15	1.17	0.76

Table 3: *t-Test for Comparison of Mean Happiness Scores across Countries*

Referent	Norway-S.A.	Norway-Cuba	S.A.-Cuba
t-value	0.8	0.1	1.0

Note: Test does not assume equal variance

It is noticed in Tables 2 and 3 that there are no significant differences in mean values of happiness across countries. It can be stated that Norwegians, South Africans, and Cubans in the sample are equally happy. However, there is a smaller standard deviation in Cuba with respects to Norway and South Africa; in other words, happiness in Cuba is distributed in a more egalitarian way than in the other two countries.

Conceptual-referent-for-happiness question

People in the survey were asked to evaluate each conceptual referent for happiness separately and to provide an answer in a scale that goes from 1 to 5, where 1 is associated to an ‘in complete disagreement’ answer and 5 to a ‘in complete agreement’ answer. Hence, rather than choosing just one referent, people were allowed to express their agreement with each conceptual referent. Thus, it is likely for some people to be in agreement with all referents.¹²

The following question was asked: “*Happiness can have different meanings for different people, and we can more or less agree with the different conceptions of happiness. For you, How much do you agree or disagree with the following statements about the meaning of happiness?*” The statements under consideration are the simple phrases presented in Table 1. The Cronbach alpha’s for the eight conceptual referents in the typology are $\alpha = .36$; $\alpha = .70$; and $\alpha = .51$ for the Norwegian, South African, and Cuban samples respectively.

Cross-Country Comparisons

Mean Values for Conceptual Referent Scores

Table 4 presents the mean values for each conceptual referent across countries. It is observed that Norwegians give high scores for referents such as *satisfaction*, *carpe diem*, and *enjoyment*. They also agree with a *fulfilment* referent. Norwegians clearly disagree with referents such as *utopian* and *stoicism*. In general, Norwegians tend to have - on average - outer-oriented conceptions of happiness.¹³

Table 4: Mean Values for Conceptual Referent Scores

Referent	By country		
	Norway	South Africa	Cuba
Stoicism	2.89	3.41	2.63
Virtue	3.56	4.06	3.84
Enjoyment	4.41	4.46	4.47
Carpe diem	4.46	4.35	4.03
Satisfaction	4.61	4.41	4.33
Utopian	2.04	3.34	3.92
Tranquillity	3.31	3.26	2.06
Fulfilment	4.28	4.25	4.45
Average value for scores	3.69	3.94	3.72
Number Observations	143	179	145

On average, South Africans agree with conceptions such as *enjoyment* and *satisfaction*; and in a lesser degree with conceptions such as *carpe diem*, *fulfilment* and *virtue*. There is no referent South Africans clearly disagree with.

¹² Previous research about the conceptual referent for happiness has asked the interviewed to select just one referent. Another possibility would be to ask the interviewed to allocate a given number of points among the eight conceptual referents, which would be an application of the LaBorda method.

¹³ An outer-orientation emphasizes the role of a person’s external factors in her pursue of happiness; while an inner-orientation emphasizes the role of a person’s inner or internal factors in her pursue of happiness. See Rojas (2007) for an explanation of the outer-inner classification of conceptual referents.

On average, Cubans agree with *enjoyment*, *fulfilment* and *satisfaction* conceptions. They tend to disagree with the *tranquillity* and *stoicism* conceptions. Thus, on average, outer-oriented conceptions for happiness dominate in all countries. However, Norwegians are the only group that tend to disagree with a *utopian* conception, while Cubans tend to disagree with a *tranquillity* conception. Norwegians and Cubans share their disagreement with a *stoicism* conception. It is clear that these statements are based on average scores and that some dispersion may exist within each country.

Table 5 shows the results from a statistical comparison of mean scores across countries. Therefore, it is possible to evaluate whether there are significant differences across countries in people's agreement with some conceptions of happiness.

Table 5: *t-Test for Comparison of Mean Scores across Countries*

Referent	Norway-S.Africa	Norway-Cuba	S.Africa-Cuba
Stoicism	3.5 *	1.6 **	5.1 *
Virtue	4.8 *	2.3 *	2.0 **
Enjoyment	0.5	0.6	0.1
Carpe diem	1.1	3.8 *	2.8 *
Satisfaction	2.2 *	3.1 *	0.8
Utopian	9.4 *	13.8 *	4.2 *
Tranquillity	0.4	9.2 *	8.7 *
Fulfilment	0.3	1.7 **	2.0 *

Note: * Difference is significant at 5 percent

** Difference is significant at 10 percent

Test does not assume equal variance

A comparison between Norwegians and South Africans' agreement with the different conceptions for happiness indicates that the former manifest greater agreement with the *stoicism*, *virtue* and *utopian* conceptions, while they manifest less agreement with the *satisfaction* conception. Thus, South Africans are, on average, more inner-oriented (and less outer-oriented) than Norwegians.

A comparison between Norwegians and Cubans' agreement with the different conceptions for happiness indicates that there are statistically significant differences in all but the *enjoyment* conception. Cubans show less agreement than Norwegians with the *stoicism*, *carpe diem*, *satisfaction* and *tranquillity* conceptions; and more agreement with the *virtue*, *utopian* and *fulfilment* conceptions.

There are also significant differences between South Africans and Cubans. South Africans manifest relatively more agreement with conceptions such as *stoicism*, *virtue*, *carpe diem*, and *tranquillity*; and relatively less agreement with the *utopian* and *fulfilment* conceptions.

Conceptual Referent Scores and Happiness

The CRT states that the conceptual referent for happiness a person holds may be relevant for her assessment of life as a happy one. Assessing a life as happy does not only depend on the external conditions a person faces (*livability* of the environment, in Veenhoven, 2000), but also on how this person evaluates these external conditions. The correlation between the inclination to a specific conception of happiness and the happiness level may vary across conceptual referents, showing the importance played by the conceptual referent a person holds on her life's judgement. In addition, the correlation may differ across countries, indicating that a person's judgement of her life depends on the combination of her environment-specific conditions and her criterion for making a judgement. Thus, an inclination towards a specific conception of happiness may lead

to a person's favourable assessment of her life under some specific social conditions but not under different conditions.

Table 6 shows correlations between each referent score and happiness. It is noticed that, within each country, there are important differences in the correlation between referents' scores and happiness across conceptions. There are also important differences for each referent across countries.

Table 6: *Correlations between Conceptual Referent Scores and Happiness*

By Country			
	Norway	South Africa	Cuba
Stoicism	0.20**	0.06	0.13
Virtue	0.16*	0.33**	0.04
Enjoyment	0.13	0.33**	0.17*
Carpe diem	0.12	0.40**	0.24**
Satisfaction	0.20**	0.24**	0.13
Utopian	-0.32**	-0.06	0.02
Tranquillity	-0.12	-0.05	-0.01
Fulfilment	0.15*	0.23**	0.03

Note: * Significant at 5 percent.

** Significant at 1 percent.

In Norway it is remarked that *stoicism* and *satisfaction* show relatively high positive correlations with happiness; while *virtue* and *fulfilment* are also significantly related to happiness. *Utopian* shows a significant negative correlation. The high and positive correlation between *stoicism* and happiness is noteworthy, since this referent shows a relatively low mean value in Norway. It is also noteworthy that *carpe diem* and *enjoyment*, which are referents with high mean scores, are not significantly related to happiness.

In South Africa, outer-oriented referents such as *carpe diem*, *enjoyment*, *satisfaction* and *fulfilment* are significantly related to happiness. *Virtue* is also positively and significantly related to happiness.

The Cuban case is special because happiness is high and there is little dispersion across the sample. However, it is found that the *carpe diem* score is positively and significantly related to happiness. *Enjoyment* is also related to happiness, although to a lesser degree.

Regression analysis is used to further explore the relationship between conceptual-referent scores and happiness across countries for each referent. Regression analysis is preferable because it allows studying the marginal impact of an increase in one referent score while holding the other scores constant. However, high correlation among scores implies that multicollinearity is present in the estimation. Hence, even though the estimated coefficients are unbiased, significance values for the *t*-test may be misleading. Thus, the study focuses on the estimated coefficient values, rather than on their *t*-test. The regression controls for gender, age, and years of education.

Table 7 presents the results from the exercise.

Table 7: Regression Analysis

Happiness as explained variable, conceptual-referent scores as explanatory variables						
	Norway		South Africa		Cuba	
	Coef.	Prob>t	Coef.	Prob>t	Coef.	Prob>t
Intercept	2.493	0.063	1.554	0.071	4.506	0.000
Stoicism	0.210	0.006	-0.083	0.252	0.018	0.731
Virtue	0.147	0.152	0.262	0.019	0.017	0.805
Enjoyment	-0.086	0.540	0.069	0.650	0.009	0.938
Carpe diem	-0.026	0.861	0.445	0.000	0.097	0.187
Satisfaction	0.237	0.143	0.046	0.707	0.041	0.669
Utopian	-0.306	0.000	-0.114	0.118	-0.024	0.728
Tranquillity	-0.142	0.101	-0.018	0.818	-0.035	0.557
Fulfilment	0.234	0.066	0.084	0.464	-0.034	0.709
Female	-0.077	0.739	0.113	0.627	-0.087	0.544
Age	0.004	0.812	0.025	0.150	-0.001	0.948
Education	0.026	0.650	-0.045	0.336	-0.016	0.667
R-squared	0.24		0.29		0.04	

Based on the estimated intercepts, it is observed that happiness tends to be relatively high in Cuba, and it is little sensitive to the scores for the conceptual referents and the demographic characteristics. The conceptual referent *carpe diem* constitutes the exception, showing a slightly positive relation with happiness in Cuba. The low R-square in Cuba indicates a poor goodness of fit for the regression; it seems that conceptual referent scores and basic socio-demographic variables have little explanatory power of Cuban students' happiness.

The intercept is very low in South Africa, and happiness is very sensitive to the *virtue* and the *carpe diem* scores; and it is slightly sensitive to the *utopian* score.

There are important differences across countries for the association of each conceptual-referent score to happiness. *Stoicism* has a large and slightly significant association to happiness in Norway, but its association is null in the other two countries. *Virtue* has a large and significant association to happiness in South Africa; its association is small in Norway and null in Cuba. *Carpe diem* is strongly relevant in South Africa, it is also relevant in Cuba, but it has no association to happiness in Norway. *Satisfaction* has a significant association to happiness in Norway, but no association in Cuba and South Africa. *Utopian* scores are negatively related to happiness in all three countries; its association is extremely large in Norway. *Tranquillity* is slightly related to happiness in a negative way in Norway, but not in the other countries. *Fulfilment* is strongly related to happiness in Norway, but not so in the other two countries.

Hence, it is clear that the association of each conceptual-referent score on happiness is contingent on the specific surrounding conditions; thus, it differs across countries.

The Socio-Demographics of Conceptual-Referent Scores

Using data for Mexico, Rojas (2005) found that the probability of holding a conceptual referent for happiness depends on a person's age, gender, and education. The survey gathered information about age, gender and education of the interviewed; thus, it is possible to study whether there are significant differences across countries in the relationship between a person's socio-demographic characteristics and her degree of agreement with each conceptual referent for happiness.

Socio-demographic variables in the survey

In Norway and South Africa the survey gathered information mostly from students. The Cuban survey also focused on educated people. Thus, the sample contains information for young and adult people, with age ranging between 14 and 48 years old, and a mean value in the early twenties. The Norwegian and South African samples have a large majority of females, while the Cuban sample is balanced by gender. Education is relatively high in Cuba and Norway, and it is relatively low in South Africa.

Table 8 presents the corresponding descriptive statistics for the socio-demographic variables in the survey.

Table 8: *Socio-Demographic Information*

Descriptive statistics by country					
Country	Variable	Minimum	Maximum	Mean	Std. Deviation
Norway	Age	19	48	24.4	6.0
	Gender	0	1	0.2	0.4
	Education	11	19	14.8	1.8
South Africa	Age	18	44	24.0	5.3
	Gender	0	1	0.2	0.4
	Education	9	19	13.8	1.9
Cuba	Age	14	48	22.1	4.8
	Gender	0	1	0.5	0.5
	Education	9	19	15.3	2.2

Note: age and education in years. For gender, female = 0 and male = 1.

Socio-demographic variables and conceptual-referent scores

This section studies the way in which the extent of agreement with each conceptual referent relates to a person's age, gender and education. It focuses on studying differences across countries.

Ordered - probit regressions are used because conceptual-referent scores can be understood as categorical variables, their value indicating different degrees of agreement with each specific statement.

The following specification is run to study differences across countries:

$$CR_{kij} = f_{Ordered\ Probit}(Age_i, Gender_i, Edu_i) \quad (1)$$

$$k = 1, 2, \dots, 8. \quad j = 1, 2, 3.$$

where:

CR_{ki} : score of person i in country j for conceptual referent k .

Age_i : age in years of person i .

$Gender_i$: person i 's gender. 1 if male, 0 if female.

Edu_i : education of person i , in years.

Table 9 presents the results from the econometric exercise.

Table 9: Socio-demographic Variables and Conceptual-Referent Scores

Ordered-probit regressions by country									
Sample	Variable	Stoicism	Virtue	Enjoyment	Carpe Diem	Satisfaction	Utopian	Tranquillity	Fulfilment
Norway	Gender	-0.508**	-0.276	-0.609***	-0.709***	-0.697***	0.084	-0.392*	-0.073
	Age	-0.004	0.008	0.022	0.000	-0.033*	-0.008	0.024	0.002
	Education	0.028	-0.018	0.010	0.059	-0.017	-0.050	-0.006	-0.059
South Africa	Gender	-0.437**	-0.389*	-0.626***	-0.480**	-0.653***	-0.107	-0.560***	-0.024
	Age	0.045***	0.033**	0.019	0.012	0.020	-0.006	0.030*	0.040**
	Education	-0.008	0.047	-0.020	-0.018	-0.001	0.037	0.087*	0.043
Cuba	Gender	0.213	0.095	0.357*	-0.273	0.212	-0.106	-0.200	0.164
	Age	0.023	0.017	0.034	0.049*	0.009	-0.058**	-0.026	0.042
	Education	0.009	0.046	-0.001	-0.072	-0.020	0.160***	-0.002	-0.001

Note: *** significant at 1 %

** significant at 5 %

* significant at 10 %

Significance tests for Gender, Age and Education refer to testing the null hypotheses of coefficients being equal to 0.

Stoicism

The probability of agreeing with a *stoicism* conception of happiness is smaller for men than for women in Norway and South Africa. It is slightly higher for men than for women in Cuba, although the coefficient is not statistically significant.

This probability does not change with age in Norway and Cuba, but it increases with age in South Africa.

Education does not make a difference in the probability of agreeing with a *stoicism* conception of happiness. It is important to remark that samples in the three countries consist of highly educated people; although there is some variability in years of education, all people in the sample can be considered as highly educated.

Virtue

Both in Norway and in Cuba, the probability of agreeing with a *virtue* conception of happiness is independent of a person's gender, age, and education.

It is found that in South Africa men have a lower probability than women of agreeing with this conception, and that this probability increases with age in South Africa.

Enjoyment

Men have a lower probability than women of agreeing with an *enjoyment* conception of happiness in Norway and in South Africa. The situation completely reverts for Cubans.

Age and education do not make a difference in the probability of agreeing with an *enjoyment* conception in any of the three countries under consideration.

Carpe Diem

Men manifest a lower probability of agreeing with a *carpe diem* conception than women in all three countries. This situation is very strong in Norway, a little less strong in South Africa, and almost negligible in Cuba.

This probability also increases with age in Cuba.

Satisfaction

The probability of agreeing with a *satisfaction* conception is lower for men than for women in Norway and South Africa, but not so in Cuba. Older Norwegians also have a smaller probability of agreeing with this conception.

Utopian

Gender, age and education do not make a difference in the probability of agreeing with a *utopian* conception of happiness in Norway and South Africa; this probability declines with age and increases with education in Cuba.

Tranquillity

Women have a higher probability than men of agreeing with a *tranquillity* conception of happiness in Norway and South Africa. This probability increases with age and education in South Africa.

Fulfilment

The probability of agreeing with a *fulfilment* conception of happiness increases with age in South Africa, but not so in Norway and Cuba. Gender and education do not make a difference in any country.

Conclusions

This investigation has shown that the conceptual referent for happiness may vary across countries. Students from three countries with dissimilar socio-economic, political and historical backgrounds were asked to express their agreement with a group of statements associated to different happiness conceptions.

It was found that South Africans have a greater inclination towards conceptions such as *stoicism*, *virtue* and *utopian*, and a smaller inclination towards the *satisfaction* conception, than Norwegians. Cubans have greater inclination towards conceptions such as *virtue* and *utopian*, and less inclination towards *satisfaction*, *carpe diem*, and *tranquillity*, than Norwegians. There are also significant differences between South Africans and Cubans. South Africans manifest relatively more agreement with conceptions such as *stoicism*, *virtue*, *carpe diem*, and *tranquillity*; and relatively less agreement with the *utopian* and *fulfilment* conceptions.

Heterogeneity across countries in the conceptual referent for happiness is important because the influence of external conditions on a person's assessment of life as a happy one does depend on how one evaluates these external conditions. Hence, the study of differences in socio-economic conditions across countries does not provide enough information to assess the subjective well-being situation in those countries. Due to heterogeneity in conceptual referents across countries, it is necessary to measure directly subjective well-being rather than to presume it on the basis of socio-economic conditions. Factors that are relevant for a happy life in Norway may be of little importance in Cuba and in South Africa, and vice versa. The investigation finds that Norwegian,

South African, and Cuban students in the sample are equally happy, even under very different socio-economic and political conditions. Heterogeneity across countries in the way happiness is assessed could play a role in explaining this finding.

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